

Four Thoughts, Refuge and Prostrations

Instructions on the one hundred and eleven thousand prostrations, for removing obstacles of body, speech and mind

Karma Kagyu tradition • For the benefit of all beings



Glory to the Root Lama

PALDEN TSAWAI LAMA RINPOCHE

Glorious root-lama, precious one,

DAG GI CHIWOR PEH

who crowns me

DAI DEN SHUG LA

upon a lotus & moon-disc,

KAHDRIN CHENPUH GONEH JEZUNG TEH

your great kindness

KU SUG TUG CHI NGODRUB TSALDU SOL

grant the blessing conferring the accomplishment of body, speech & mind.

PALDEN DORJE CHANG WANG

Glorious Dorje Chang,

RIGKUN CHABDAG LAMA KARMAPA

universal lord of all Buddha families, the Lama Karmapa,

CHILKHOR KUNJI JUNGNEH SISHI PALJUR YIDAM NALJORMA

Yidam Dorje Naljorma, source of all mandalas,

TRINLEH KUNJI JEHPOR WANGJUR CHOCHONG BERCHE CHAMDREL LA

dharma protector Dorje Bernagchen and consort, powerful masters of all enlightened activity.

NALJOR TSECHIG GUHPAE DUDO DRELMEH TUGJEH CHONGWAR DZUH

The practitioner, with one-pointed devotion, bows down and requests to be inseparable from the protection of your compassion.

The Four Thoughts That Turn the Mind

1 PRECIOUS LIFE

DANGPO GOMJA DALJOR RINCHEN DI

Firstly, meditate on the precious eighteen conditions

TOBKAH JIGLA DARAY DUNYUH JA

hard to obtain, easy to lose, which this time should be used with purpose.

2 IMPERMANENCE

NYIPA NUHCHU TAMCHEH MITAG CHING

Secondly the entire universe and its contents are impermanent,

GUHSU DROWAI TSESOG CHUBUR DRA

especially the life-force of sentient beings which is like a bubble.

NAMCHI CHAMEH SHI TSE RORU JUR

At the time of death, we die alone and one's body becomes a corpse

DELA CHOCHI PENCHIR TSONPAE DRUB

at that time only the dharma is of benefit, so practice with diligence.

3 KARMA, CAUSE AND EFFECT

SUMPA SHI TSE RANGWANG MINDU WAR

Thirdly, at the time of death one's freedom will be lost,

LEHNI DAG GIR JACHIR DIG PA PANG

usurped by one's karma; therefore, abandon defilements.

GEWAI JAWAE TAGTU DAHWAR JA

and accumulate virtue continuously until death.

SHEHSAM NYIN REHRANG JU NYI LA TAG

With this in mind, examine one's motivation every day.

4 THE FAULTS OF SAMSA RA

SHIPA KHORWAI NEHDRA DROG DEJOR SOG

Fourthly, all places, friends, enjoyments, wealth and so on

DUG NGAL SUMJI TAGTU NARWAI CHIR

continuously causes torment of the three sufferings,

SUHSAR TRIPAI SHEHMAI GAHTUN TAR

instead of celebrating as the hangman leads you to your death,

SHENTRI CHEHNEH TSONPAE JANGCHUB DRUB

cut through attachments and diligently strive for enlightenment

Allow a one to fifteen-minute contemplation of the four thoughts.

Visualisation, Taking Refuge and Bodhicitta

DUNDU TSO-U PAGSAM JUNSHING GI

In front of one is a lake, and in its centre a wish-fulfilling tree

DONGPO TSAWA CHIGLA YELGA NGAR

with a single trunk and five branches

JEHPAI U-MAR SENGTRI PEMA DANG

in the centre where the branches divide is a lion-throne, a lotus,

NYIDAI TENGDU TSAWAI LA MANI

a sun, a moon, upon which is one's root-lama

DORJE CHANG LA KAHJU LAMAE KOR

in the form of Dorje Chang, surrounded by the Kagyu lamas.

DUNDU YIDAM YEHSU SANGJEH DANG

In front are the Yidams, to the right the buddhas,

JABTU DAMCHO YUNDU GENDUN DANG

behind the pure dharma, to the left the sangha,

DENTRI OGTU CHOCHONG SUNGMA NAM

and below the throne are the host of dharma protectors and guardians,

SOSOI RIGTUN KHOR TSOK JAMTSUH KOR

each surrounded by an ocean-like multitude of their kind.

TSOTAH NEUSENG TENGDU KHACHAB CHI

Beside the lake upon a verdant meadow and pervading the sky

MAGEN TAMCHEH KUHPAR JURPA LEH

all of my previous mothers appear,

TSECHIG YICHI CHABDRO SEMCHEH JUR

all of us one-pointedly resolved on taking refuge.

TAKING REFUGE

DAGDANG NAMKHAI TAHDANG NYAMPAL SEMCHEN

I and all sentient beings throughout the universe take refuge in the embodiment,

TAMCHEH CHOGCHU DUSUM JI DESHIN SHEGPA TAMCHEH CHI KU SUNG TUG YONTEN

TRINLEH TAMCHEH CHIGTU DUHPAI NGOWOR JUR PA

the very essence of the body, speech, mind, activity, and quality of all of the Buddhas of the ten directions and the three times,

CHOCHI PUNGPO TONGTRAG JEHCHU TSA SHI JUNGNEH

source of the eighty-four thousand dharma collection,

PAGPAI GENDUN TAMCHEH CHI NGAH DAG

the master of all the noble Sangha,

DRINCHEN TSAWA DANG JUHPAR CHEHPAI

the kind root and lineage ones;

Recite During Prostrations

PALDEN LAMA DAMPA NAMLA CHABSU CHIO

In the glorious lamas, the superior ones, I take refuge

YIDAM CHILKHOR JI LHA TSOK NAMLA CHABSU CHIO

In the host of Yidams, the deities of the mandalas, I take refuge

SANGJEH CHOM DENDEH NAMLA CHABSU CHIO

In the victorious Buddhas, I take refuge.

DAMPAI CHO NAMLA CHABSU CHIO

In the pure dharma I take refuge.

PAGPAI GENDUN NAMLA CHABSU CHIO

In the exalted sangha I take refuge.

PAHWO KHANDRO CHOCHONG SUNGMAI TSO YESHE CHI CHENDANG DENPA NAMLA CHABSU CHIO

In the host of deities possessing the wisdom-eye, the dakas, dakinis, dharma protectors and guardians, I take refuge.

Repeat seven, twenty-one, or as many times as one can.

Bodhisattva Vow

JANGCHUB NYINGPOR CHICHI BAR

Until the heart of enlightenment is realised

SANGJEH NAMLA CHABSU CHIO

I take refuge in the Buddhas,

CHO DANG JANGCHUB SEMPAH YI

in the dharma and bodhisattvas

TSOG LA-ANG DESHIN CHABSU CHIO

the host of realized ones, I take refuge.

JITAR NGONJI DESHEG CHI

Just as the realized ones of the past

JANGCHUB TUGNI CHEHPA DANG

engendered the enlightenment-heart

JANGCHUB SEMPAI LABPA LA

and the bodhisattva training

DEHDAG RIMSHIN NEHPA TAR

through their successive levels,

DESHIN DRO LA PENDUN DU

likewise, for the benefit of all sentient beings

JANGCHUB SEMNI CHEHJI SHING

I will generate bodhicitta

DESHIN DUNI LABPA LA-ANG

and in the same way train,

RIMPA SHINDU LABPAR JI

throughout the succeeding levels.

Repeat three times.

TO UPLIFT ONESELF**DENGDUH DAGTSE DREBU YUH**

From today my life has become fruitful

MIYI SIPA LEGPAR TOB

my human life has become worthy

DERING SANGJEH RIGSU CHEH

today I have been born into the Buddha's family

SANGJEH SEHSU DAG DENG JUR

from today I become a child of Buddha.

DANI DAG GI CHINAY CHANG

In the future I will always

RIGDANG TUNPAI LEH TSAM TEH

behave in accordance with this association

CHUNMEH TSUNPAI RIGDI LA

so that our noble, faultless family

NYOGPAR MIN JUR DEHTAR JA

remains undefiled.

OTHER PRAISES**DAG GI DERING CHOBPA TAMCHEH CHI**

I, today, before the entire refuge

CHEN NGAR DROWA DESHEG NYIDANG NI

invite all beings to attain enlightenment

BARDU DEHLA DRONDU BUHZIN JI

and until then enjoy happiness

LHA DANG LHAMIN LASOG GAHWAR JI

thus gods & mortals, and so on, rejoice.

Bodhicitta Aspiration Prayers

JANGCHUB SEMNI RINPOCHE

May the precious bodhicitta

MACHEH PA NAM CHEHJUR CHIG

take birth where it is not existing,

CHEHPA NYAMPA MEHPA DANG

where it exists may it never wane

GONGNEH GONGDU PELWAR SHOG

but continuously increase.

JANGCHUB SEMDANG MI DREL SHING

May we be inseparable from bodhicitta

JANGCHUB CHUHLA SHOL WA DANG

may bodhisattva conduct be diligently engaged.

SANGJEH NAMCHI YONG ZUNG SHING

Through the Buddhas accomplishments,

DUCHI LEHNAM PONGWAR SHOG

may those with harmful intent be repelled.

JANGCHUB SEMPAH NAMCHI NI

May all of the bodhisattvas

DRODUN TUGLA GONG DRUB SHOG

fulfil their objectives for the benefit of others,

GONPO YINI GANG GONG PA

and through their all-enfolding protection

SEMCHEN NAMLA DEJOR SHOG

may all sentient beings have abundant happiness.

SEMCHEN TAMCHEH DEDANG DENJUR CHIG

May all sentient beings have happiness

NGENDRO TAMCHEH TAGTU TONGPAR SHOG

may all the lower realms be empty forever,

JANGCHUB SEMPAH GANGDAG SAR SHUGPA

may the bodhisattvas fulfil their objectives,

DEYDAG KUNJI MONLAM DRUBPAR SHOG

and in this way may all the aspiration prayers be fulfilled.

The Four Limitless Thoughts

SEMCHEN TAMCHEH DEWA DANG, DEWAI JUDANG DENPAR JUR CHIG

May all sentient beings have happiness and the causes of happiness,

DUG NGAL DANG, DUG NGALJI JUDANG DRELWAR JUR CHIG

may they be free from suffering and the causes of suffering,

DUG NGAL MEHPAI DEWA DAMPA DANG MIDRELWAR JUR CHIG

may they be inseparable from the joy-beyond-suffering

NYERING CHAGDANG NYI DANG DRELWAI TANG NYOM CHENPO LA NEHPAR JURCHIG

may they remain in the great equanimity beyond attachment or aversion.

Repeat three times.

TAHMAR CHABYUL O-SHU DAGDANG DREH

Lastly the source of refuge melts into light which merges with me.

Dedication and Aspiration

GEDI DROWA MALU DORJE SEM

Through this merit may all sentient beings without exception become vajra beings,

TAGDEI TABSHEH JORWAE CHIMEH CHI

the permanent bliss of means and wisdom, united eternally,

NANG GI LAMNEH DORJER DROWA YI

and may beings, by travelling the vajra inner path

SANGJEH NYICHI GO PANG TSOL CHIR NGO

attain the level of the Buddha itself – to that end I dedicate.

GEWA DIYI NYURDU DAG

Through this merit may I quickly

CHAGJA CHENPO DRUBJUR NEH

gain the accomplishment of Mahamudra,

DROWA CHIG CHANG MALU PA

that I may lead all sentient beings without exception

DEYI SALA GUH PAR SHOG

to that level, may it be so!

SANGJEH KUSUM NYEHPAI JINLAB DANG

Through the blessings of the three bodies of the buddhas,

CHONYI MINJUR DENPAI JINLAB DANG

through the blessings of the unchanging truth of the Dharmata,

GEN DUN MICHEH DUNPAI JINLAB CHI

through the blessings of the pure aspirations of the undiminished sangha,

JITAR NGOWA MONLAM DRUBPAR SHOG

may the aspirations and dedications be realized.

DECHEN TSOKJI KHORLOR TAG ROLPA

You who continuously turn the wheel of the accumulation of great bliss,

DUSUM JAL WAI TERCHEN KARMAPA

great treasure revealer of the Buddhas of the three times, Karmapa,

YABSEH JUPAR CHEHPA SI TSO DIR

the lineage holders and followers, in this ocean of samsara

KALPA KALPAI BARDU SHABTEN SOL

please remain for Aeon upon Aeon.

GANG GI ZABSANG SUNG GI SANGWA LA

The secret holders of the profound secret teachings,

TUHSAM DRUBPA NYINGPOR JERPA YI

through listening, reflecting and practicing you have taken them to your heart,

PONG DANG LOGPAI DENAM TAMCHEY NI

may all the gatherings of hermits and scholars

YARJI CHUWO TABUR JEH JUR CHIG

increase like rivers in the rainy season.

PALDEN LAMA SHABPAY TENPA DANG

May the glorious lamas remain steadfast on their lotus-feet (i.e. live long),

KHA NYAM YONGLA DECHI JUNGWA DANG

may bliss and happiness spread far and wide like the sky.

DAGSHEN MALU TSOB SAG DRIB JANG NEH

May I and all sentient beings amass our accumulations, purify our obscurations,

NYURDU SANGJEH SALA GUHPAR SHOG

quickly being established at the level of the buddhas.

By the virtue of seeing, hearing, remembering, or touching this text, may all sentient beings take birth in the pure land of great bliss!

May the auspicious Karma Kagyu teachings, blazing with splendour, increase throughout the ten directions as the ornament of the world.

May all be auspicious!

Happiness! Happiness! Happiness!



The Karma Kagyu refuge tree

*Unofficially compiled from teachings beautifully given by Lama Rabsang in 2025.
May his words send ripples of love and awakening throughout the ten directions and three times.*